
A PERSONAL MASTER COURSE FOR ICSE

JULIUS CAESAR

Act 2 — The Basics

The short guide to Act 2: what happens, what the hard lines mean, who the people are, ten quotations, and how to answer a basic question

Prepared for an ICSE Class 10 student · Based on the verified Shakespeare text (Folger / Globe editions) ·
Cross-checked against Plutarch and modern Roman history · Aligned to the CISCE Literature in English paper

Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper (Acts III–V) depends on it at every turn. This book teaches Act 1 from zero to examination standard.

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FRONT MATTER

Act 2 Basics: The Night Before the Ides

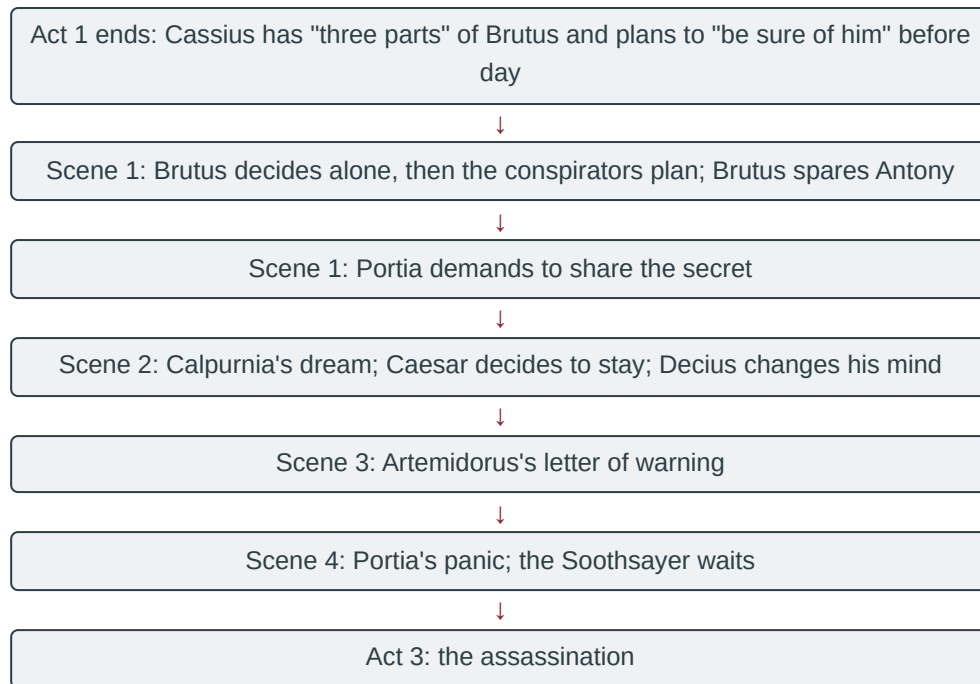
What this chapter does: it teaches Act 2 of Julius Caesar from zero in the shortest useful form. You will learn what happens in each of the four scenes, what the hardest lines mean, who the people are, the ten quotations worth knowing, and how to answer a basic examination question. Every quotation has been checked against the Folger and Globe texts.

ICSE EXAM BOX Where Act 2 sits in your syllabus

Acts I and II are the Class IX portion of the ICSE Julius Caesar syllabus; the Class X board paper examines Acts III–V. Act 2 is nonetheless essential background for Act 3: it is where Brutus decides, where the conspirators plan the murder, and where Caesar ignores every warning. Nothing here is a prediction of a specific question.

Act 2 in one minute

It is the night of 14 March, during the storm. Brutus, alone in his orchard, talks himself into killing Caesar for Rome's sake, reads the forged letters, and welcomes the conspirators. He takes charge: no oath, no Cicero, and, fatally, no killing of Antony. His wife Portia begs to share his secret. At dawn in Caesar's house, Calpurnia, terrified by her dream of Caesar's statue running blood, persuades Caesar to stay at home, but Decius Brutus flatters him into going. A teacher, Artemidorus, waits in the street with a letter naming the conspirators. Portia, half-mad with anxiety, sends Lucius to the Capitol and meets the Soothsayer, who is still trying to warn Caesar. The act ends with Caesar on his way to the Senate.



The people of Act 2

Character	Who they are	What they do in Act 2
Brutus	Caesar's friend; a respected noble Roman	Decides to kill Caesar for the public good; leads the conspiracy; refuses an oath, excludes Cicero, spares Antony
Cassius	The organiser of the plot	Brings the conspirators to Brutus; wants an oath, Cicero and Antony's death; gives way to Brutus each time
Portia	Brutus's wife, daughter of Cato	Demands to know his secret; wounds her thigh to prove her strength; collapses with anxiety in Scene 4
Lucius	Brutus's servant boy	Finds the letter; sleeps soundly, which Brutus envies
Decius Brutus	A conspirator who knows Caesar's vanity	Reinterprets Calpurnia's dream and talks Caesar into going out
Casca, Cinna, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius	Conspirators	Join the planning; Metellus brings in Ligarius
Caius Ligarius	A sick nobleman who hates Caesar	Throws off his sickness to follow Brutus
Caesar	Dictator of Rome	Ignores his wife, the priests and the omens; goes to the Senate
Calpurnia	Caesar's wife	Dreams of his murder and begs him to stay
Antony	Caesar's loyal friend	Appears briefly; Brutus has just decided to spare him
Artemidorus	A teacher of rhetoric	Writes a letter warning Caesar of every conspirator
The Soothsayer	The man from Act 1	Still waiting to warn Caesar on the Ides

Scene 1 — Brutus's orchard: the decision

What happens

1. Brutus cannot sleep. Alone, he reasons that Caesar must die, not for anything he has done, but for what a crown might make him become.
2. Lucius brings a sealed letter found at the window: one of Cassius's forgeries. Brutus reads it as the voice of Rome calling him to act, and remembers his ancestor who drove out the Tarquin king.
3. Lucius confirms the date: tomorrow is the Ides of March. Brutus admits he has not slept since Cassius first stirred him.
4. The conspirators arrive, faces hidden in cloaks. Brutus is disgusted that conspiracy needs darkness.
5. Brutus takes command. Three decisions: no oath (honest Romans do not need one); leave out Cicero (he will never follow another man's plan); do not kill Antony (he is only "a limb of Caesar"). Cassius disagrees on the last two and loses.
6. Cassius worries that the superstitious Caesar may not come; Decius promises to flatter him out of the house.
7. Portia confronts Brutus. She has watched him sigh, stamp and stare; she kneels; she claims her right as his wife; she reveals the wound she gave herself in the thigh to prove her constancy. Brutus promises to tell her everything.
8. Ligarius arrives, sick, and declares himself cured by the mere prospect of following Brutus in an honourable exploit.

The hard lines, made simple

Brutus: *It must be by his death. And for my part / I know no personal cause to spurn at him, / But for the general.*

Simple English: The only solution is to kill him. I have no private grudge; it is for the public good. **Why it matters:** Brutus begins with the conclusion and then searches for the reasons. The soliloquy is honest about this: Caesar has not yet done wrong, so Brutus must argue from what he *might* do. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers see this as the moment a good man reasons his way into a crime.

Brutus: *It is the bright day that brings forth the adder, / And that craves wary walking.*

Simple English: Success and power (bright day) bring out the snake; so we must step carefully. **Difficult words:** adder = poisonous snake; craves = demands; wary = careful.

Brutus: *That lowliness is young ambition's ladder, / Whereto the climber-upward turns his face; / But, when he once attains the upmost round, / He then unto the ladder turns his back*

Simple English: Ambitious men act humble while climbing; once at the top they despise the people who helped them up. **Device:** extended metaphor (the ladder). **Keyword:** ambition, hypocrisy of the climber.

Brutus: *And therefore think him as a serpent's egg, / Which, hatched, would, as his kind, grow mischievous, / And kill him in the shell.*

Simple English: Treat Caesar as an unhatched snake: destroy him before he can become dangerous. **Why it matters:** The logic is prevention, not punishment. Brutus himself says "Then, lest he may, prevent." Notice the quiet admission that "the quarrel / Will bear no colour for the thing he is": the case against Caesar as he now is

would not convince anyone, so Brutus must "Fashion it".

Brutus: *Between the acting of a dreadful thing / And the first motion, all the interim is / Like a phantasma or a hideous dream.*

Simple English: The time between deciding on a terrible act and doing it feels like a nightmare. **Difficult words:** interim = the time between; phantasma = a vision or nightmare. Brutus then compares the self to "a little kingdom" suffering "an insurrection": his inner civil war mirrors the one coming to Rome.

Brutus: *O conspiracy, / Sham'st thou to show thy dang'rous brow by night, / When evils are most free?*

Simple English: Conspiracy, are you ashamed to show your face even at night, when evil moves most freely?

Device: apostrophe (addressing an abstraction) and personification. Brutus is uneasy that a cause he calls honourable needs disguise.

Brutus: *Let's be sacrificers, but not butchers, Caius.*

Simple English: Let us kill Caesar as a solemn religious offering, not as a slaughter. **Why it matters:** This is Brutus's idealism in one line: he wants a clean, noble killing, "a dish fit for the gods". He also wants the conspirators to be seen as "purgers, not murderers". Act 3 will test whether a murder can ever be made to look like a sacrifice.

Brutus: *For Antony is but a limb of Caesar.*

Simple English: Antony is only a part of Caesar's body; cut off the head and the arm is useless. **Why it matters:** This is the mistake of the play. Cassius wants Antony dead; Brutus overrules him. Antony's speech in Act 3 Scene 2 will prove Cassius right.

Portia: *Dwell I but in the suburbs / Of your good pleasure? If it be no more, / Portia is Brutus' harlot, not his wife.*

Simple English: Do I live only on the outskirts of your affection? If so I am your mistress, not your wife.

Difficult words: suburbs = the outer edge (in Shakespeare's London the suburbs were where brothels stood); harlot = prostitute.

Portia: *I grant I am a woman, but withal / A woman well-reputed, Cato's daughter.*

Simple English: Yes, I am a woman, but one of good reputation, and the daughter of Cato. **Historical record:** Cato the Younger was a famous Stoic who killed himself rather than live under Caesar. Portia claims his strength; her self-inflicted "voluntary wound" is the proof.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Brutus wins every argument and loses the play

Cassius is right three times in Scene 1: an oath would bind the plotters, Cicero's "silver hairs" would lend respectability, and Antony is dangerous. Brutus overrules him each time, and each time the conspirators defer, because Brutus's reputation is exactly what they recruited him for. Shakespeare shows that the quality that makes Brutus valuable, his moral authority, is also what makes the conspiracy politically blind. He judges Antony by his own standards ("given / To sports, to wildness, and much company") and cannot imagine a reveller being a strategist.

Scene 2 — Caesar's house: the warnings

What happens

1. The storm continues. Calpurnia has cried out in her sleep three times, "Help ho, they murder Caesar!" Caesar sends for the priests to sacrifice.
2. Calpurnia begs him not to go out. She lists the night's horrors: a lioness giving birth in the streets, graves opening, fiery warriors fighting in the clouds, blood drizzling on the Capitol, ghosts shrieking.
3. Caesar answers with fatalism and bravado: "Cowards die many times before their deaths". The priests report a sacrificed animal with no heart; Caesar reads even this as a rebuke to cowardice.
4. Calpurnia kneels. Caesar gives way "for thy humour" and will send Antony to say he is unwell.
5. Decius arrives. Caesar refuses to send a lie, then tells him Calpurnia's dream: his statue running blood like a fountain while smiling Romans bathe their hands in it.
6. Decius reinterprets the dream as a vision of Rome drawing new life from Caesar, adds that the Senate means to offer him a crown today, and hints that people will mock him for obeying his wife. Caesar is ashamed and goes.
7. The conspirators arrive to escort him. Caesar greets each warmly and invites them to drink wine "like friends". Brutus, aside, grieves that "every like is not the same".

The hard lines, made simple

Caesar: *Caesar shall forth. The things that threatened me / Ne'er looked but on my back. When they shall see / The face of Caesar, they are vanishèd.*

Simple English: Caesar will go out. Dangers only ever attack me from behind; face to face they disappear.

Why it matters: The third-person self-reference ("Caesar shall forth") is the public mask from Act 1. In the Senate the danger will indeed come face to face, from friends.

Calpurnia: *When beggars die there are no comets seen; / The heavens themselves blaze forth the death of princes.*

Simple English: Nature does not mark the death of ordinary people; comets appear only when a great man is about to die. **Why it matters:** An Elizabethan idea that the heavens mirror the state. Calpurnia reads the omens correctly; Caesar refuses to.

Caesar: *Cowards die many times before their deaths; / The valiant never taste of death but once.*

Simple English: A coward suffers death in imagination again and again; a brave man dies only once, in fact.

Why it matters: The most famous line in Act 2. It is genuinely noble, and it is also the reasoning that kills him. Caesar adds that death "Will come when it will come": fatalism dressed as courage.

Caesar: *Danger knows full well / That Caesar is more dangerous than he. / We are two lions littered in one day, / And I the elder and more terrible.*

Simple English: Danger knows I am more dangerous than it is. We are twin lions, and I am the elder and fiercer. **Device:** personification of Danger; hyperbole. Calpurnia's reply names the flaw exactly: "Your wisdom is consumed in confidence."

Decius: *This dream is all amiss interpreted. / It was a vision fair and fortunate.*

Simple English: The dream has been misread; it is a good omen. **Why it matters:** Decius does what Cicero warned of in Act 1 Scene 3: he construes the sign 'after his fashion'. He also knows Caesar's weakness, telling the conspirators that Caesar "loves to hear" flattery while claiming to hate it. The crown ("the Senate have concluded / To give this day a crown to mighty Caesar") is the bait.

Brutus: *That every like is not the same, O Caesar, / The heart of Brutus earns to think upon.*

Simple English: Not everyone who looks like a friend is one, Caesar; it grieves Brutus's heart to think of it.

Difficult word: earns = grieves (an old form of 'yearns'). **Device:** dramatic irony. Caesar has just said "we, like friends, will straightway go together."

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Two households, one night

Shakespeare builds Act 2 on a pair of mirrors. Brutus will not sleep; Caesar cannot. A wife kneels to Brutus and wins the truth; a wife kneels to Caesar and wins an hour, then loses. Brutus refuses to let his looks "put on our purposes"; Caesar insists that his face makes danger vanish. The two great men are shown as husbands before they are shown as killer and victim, so that the audience feels the private cost of a public act.

Scene 3 — The street: Artemidorus

Artemidorus, a teacher, reads aloud a letter he has written for Caesar. It names every conspirator in turn ("Caesar, beware of Brutus, take heed of Cassius, come not near Casca...") and warns: "Security gives way to conspiracy." He will offer it as a petition when Caesar passes.

Difficult word: security = over-confidence, false sense of safety (not 'protection'). **Why the scene exists:** it is a short, prose scene in the open air between two tense indoor scenes; it tells the audience that Caesar could still be saved, which tightens the suspense; and its closing couplet ("If thou read this, O Caesar, thou mayest live; / If not, the Fates with traitors do contrive") sets fate against free will one last time before the murder.

Scene 4 — Before Brutus's house: Portia and the Soothsayer

Portia, who now knows the secret, cannot keep still. She sends Lucius to the Capitol with no clear errand, imagines she hears a "bustling rumour like a fray", and confesses her weakness: "I have a man's mind but a woman's might. / How hard it is for women to keep counsel!" The Soothsayer passes on his way to warn Caesar; he fears "much that...may chance". Portia nearly gives the plot away and sends Lucius to tell Brutus she is "merry".

Why the scene exists: it dramatises the cost of the secret on the person who begged for it; it shows that the Soothsayer's warning and Artemidorus's letter are both still in play; and it lets the clock run (it is "About the ninth hour") so that Act 3 opens at the Capitol.

Themes of Act 2 in brief

Theme	Where you see it	One line to use
Honour and idealism	Brutus's refusal of an oath; "sacrificers, but not butchers"	Brutus wants the murder to be as noble as his reasons

Theme	Where you see it	One line to use
Ambition	The ladder image; "He would be crowned"	Brutus condemns an ambition Caesar has not yet shown
Public duty vs private feeling	"no personal cause...But for the general"; Portia's demand	Both husbands sacrifice the private self to the public role
Omens, fate and free will	Calpurnia's dream; the heartless beast; Artemidorus's couplet	Every warning is given; every warning is interpreted away
Manipulation and flattery	Decius on Caesar; the forged letters working on Brutus	Both great men are moved by words shaped to their vanity
Appearance vs reality	Cloaked conspirators; "look fresh and merrily"; "like friends"	The plot survives only by acting
Loyalty and friendship	Ligarius; Portia; Caesar's warm greetings	Loyalty is given sincerely by some and performed by others
Pride and over-confidence	"Caesar is more dangerous than he"	Calpurnia names it: "Your wisdom is consumed in confidence"

Ten quotations to know

Speaker	Quotation	Use it for
Brutus	"It must be by his death."	Brutus's decision; prevention not punishment
Brutus	"lowliness is young ambition's ladder"	Ambition; the hypocritical climber
Brutus	"think him as a serpent's egg...And kill him in the shell"	Pre-emptive logic; snake imagery
Brutus	"Let's be sacrificers, but not butchers"	Idealism; the attempt to purify murder
Brutus	"For Antony is but a limb of Caesar."	The fatal misjudgement
Portia	"Portia is Brutus' harlot, not his wife."	Marriage, dignity, the right to share
Portia	"A woman well-reputed, Cato's daughter."	Portia's strength; the Stoic inheritance
Calpurnia	"The heavens themselves blaze forth the death of princes."	Omens; the heavens mirroring the state
Caesar	"Cowards die many times before their deaths"	Caesar's courage and fatalism; dramatic irony
Decius	"This dream is all amiss interpreted."	Flattery; interpretation as a weapon

Words that trip students up

Word	Meaning here
spurn at	kick against, attack
the general	the public good
craves	demands
remorse	pity, compassion ("disjoins / Remorse from power")
base degrees	the low rungs (of the ladder); the humble people who helped
colour	justification, excuse ("bear no colour")
exhalations	meteors (the fiery lights of the storm)

Word	Meaning here
whet	sharpen, incite
interim	the time in between
phantasma	nightmare vision
genius	guiding spirit
palter	equivocate, go back on one's word
cautalous	crafty, deceitful
carrions	corpses (contemptuously, of feeble old men)
purgers	healers who cleanse
o'ersway	overrule, persuade
humour	mood, whim ("for thy humour I will stay at home")
augurers	priests who read omens
cognizance	a badge or token of allegiance
earns	grieves
security	over-confidence
emulation	envious rivalry
counsel	a secret

Connections: what Act 2 picks up from Act 1 and hands to Act 3

Act 1 seed	Act 2 development	Act 3 consequence
Cassius plans forged letters "in several hands"	Brutus reads one and 'pieces it out' into a summons from Rome	Brutus kills Caesar believing he answers Rome's call
Cassius: "Three parts of him / Is ours already"	Brutus decides before Cassius even arrives	Brutus, not Cassius, leads, and his decisions shape the aftermath
Caesar: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear"	Caesar: "Caesar is more dangerous than he"	Caesar refuses the petition and is killed
The Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March"	Brutus asks "Is not tomorrow, boy, the ides of March?"; the Soothsayer waits in Scene 4	'The ides of March are come' (Act 3 Scene 1)
Cicero: men "construe things after their fashion"	Decius construes Calpurnia's dream	The dream comes true in the blood-bathed hands of Act 3 Scene 1
Caesar dismisses Cassius's fear of Antony as needless	Brutus dismisses Cassius's wish to kill Antony	Antony's funeral speech turns Rome against the conspirators
Casca's storm and prodigies	Calpurnia's catalogue of horrors	The omens prove true

How to answer a basic Act 2 question

ICSE EXAM BOX The three moves

1. **Place it.** Say who speaks, to whom, and at what moment. 'Brutus speaks these words alone in his orchard on the night before the Ides, before the conspirators arrive.'
2. **Explain it.** Put the line into plain English and gloss the hard word. 'By "the general" he means the public good: he admits he has no private grievance.'
3. **Say why it matters.** Character, theme, or what it leads to. 'This shows Brutus's idealism and the weakness of his case: he must condemn Caesar for what he might become, which prepares us for the doubts of Act 3.' Each move is roughly one mark in a three-mark sub-question.

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer to 'Why does Caesar decide to go to the Senate?'

Caesar decides to go because Decius tells him to. Calpurnia had a dream but Decius says it is a good dream. Caesar also wants the crown. So he goes and gets killed.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer to the same question

Caesar had agreed to stay at home "for thy humour", yielding to Calpurnia's dream of his statue running blood. Decius reverses this in three steps: he reinterprets the dream as a sign that Rome will draw "Reviving blood" from Caesar; he announces that the Senate means to offer "a crown to mighty Caesar" that very day; and he suggests that senators will whisper "Lo, Caesar is afraid" if he hides behind his wife's dreams. Decius has earlier boasted that he can "give his humour the true bent", and he does so by appealing to Caesar's ambition and his horror of seeming a coward. Caesar's "How foolish do your fears seem now, Calphurnia!" shows that pride, not reason, has decided, exactly as Calpurnia warned: "Your wisdom is consumed in confidence."

Why the excellent answer earns marks: it names the sequence of events, quotes short verified phrases, explains the method of persuasion, and ends on the character point that the examiner is looking for.

Practice questions

1. Explain, with reference to the soliloquy, why Brutus decides that Caesar "must" die although he knows "no personal cause". What image does he use for Caesar? [3]
2. What three decisions does Brutus make when the conspirators meet, and what does Cassius want instead? Which decision proves most costly later? [3]
3. How does Portia persuade Brutus to share his secret? What does the "voluntary wound" show about her? [3]
4. Describe Calpurnia's dream and Decius's reinterpretation of it. [3]
5. 'Caesar's courage and Caesar's vanity are the same thing.' How far does Act 2 Scene 2 support this view? Give reasons. [4]

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 2

Five events: Brutus's soliloquy and the letter; the conspirators' plan (no oath, no Cicero, no killing Antony); Portia's plea and wound; Calpurnia's dream and Decius's flattery; Artemidorus and the Soothsayer wait to warn Caesar. **Five words:** the general; serpent's egg; sacrificers not butchers; limb of Caesar; amiss interpreted. **Three quotations:** "It must be by his death."; "Cowards die many times before their deaths"; "Let's be sacrificers, but not butchers". **Three character points:** Brutus reasons from what Caesar might become; Portia claims a Stoic's strength; Caesar's confidence overrides every warning. **Three themes:** honour versus political judgement; omens, fate and free will; manipulation through flattery. **Two devices:** extended metaphor (the ladder, the serpent's egg); dramatic irony (Caesar's "like friends"). **Two historical points:** Portia was Cato's daughter; Plutarch records Calpurnia's dream and Decimus Brutus persuading Caesar to attend. **Three connections:** forged letters (Act 1) → Brutus's decision; sparing Antony → Antony's funeral speech (Act 3); "Is not tomorrow...the ides of March?" → 'The ides of March are come' (Act 3 Scene 1). **One central idea:** Act 2 shows two great men ignoring the people who love them, for the sake of a public image.